

Awe and the Sublime in Cinema

INTRODUCTION

A main focus of our course material thus far has been the idea that awe and wonder is primarily derived from nature. Walking and enjoying natural spaces is one of the greatest sources of emotional fulfillment and everyday awe. Natural spaces such as the national parks also act as sublime, spiritual places, capable of causing tremendous feelings of connectedness and transcendence.

While I fully agree with our previous conclusions, I wish to expand our inquiry into sources of awe that are purely artificial, in our case film. My goal is to argue that awe is at the very core of film as a medium. Even further, crafting a sublime experience for the audience is *essential* to a film's effectiveness.

This experience is characterized by a mix of distinct elements such as the soundtrack, cinematography, editing, script, and acting. These elements come together to create a complex fusion of storytelling elements and aesthetics. If executed well, this fusion operates in such an abstract and subliminal nature as to confound the mind. In the spirit of Kant's sublime, this puts our brain in a state of "agitation" because we cannot fully reason how the film is functioning. We become so utterly convinced and immersed in the setting or idea. The sublime is fully realized when the film leaves us room to realize our own wonder at this experience.

I'd like to note early in this exploration that this characterization of film might not fit completely for all genres, namely comedy. In many examples the aesthetic qualities of a comedy or parody are less important in determining the overall quality of the film as its goal is not to elicit awe. However, well-crafted comedic writing can lead to a high energy climax at the end of the film, also creating this sublime effect.

I would also like to note that while a film itself is wholly artificial in terms of its abstract form (a motion picture is not a product of nature), its basis in the world is not. The form and content of films are based in our real world and everyday lives, in trying to represent what it means to be human. Yes, a film is artificial, but in fact it draws its power from nature itself. A film succeeds at inspiring wonder by calling our attention to the world around us with a unique perspective, much like the awe walks we've been practicing. Perceiving our world through a finite, bordered rectangle on a screen gives us epiphanies we could never have otherwise.

Filmmaker Georges Méliès is famous for his innovative use of special effects around the turn of the century. Before he made films, Méliès was a magician. When he later transitioned into the emerging medium of filmmaking, he discovered he was able to apply much of what he had previously learned. A feature by Fountaindale Public Library District describes this transition, "Fantastic illusions impossible to perform in real life. Slight of hands on a massive scale unlocked by the power of editing. The hearse magically taking the place of the trolley foreshadowed not only Méliès' devotion to his mind's illusions but also his love for macabre, satanic and evil characters and themes... He would pioneer numerous groundbreaking film techniques that are still employed to this day, including the stop edit, double and multiple exposure and the dissolve."¹ It turns out that a film is really just one big magic trick. Méliès is famous for directing the silent short, *A Trip to the Moon* (1902), the first ever science fiction film. He employed special effects and editing techniques to depict character deaths, and used painted set designs to depict vast, unexplored landscapes such as the surface of the Moon. The sublime quality of a film is drawn from how it appears to us as "magic."

With that we can dive into several relevant articles on the matter, beginning with "The 'Sublime' Aesthetic in American Independent Cinema: Incomprehensibility, Violence, Awe and

¹ Clemens (2023)

Paradox,” by Karin Badt.² She argues that American arthouse films achieve sublimity through alienating, shocking, and confusing images which leverage the “painful” awe and metacognitive wonder defined by Kant and Burke. Most notably she coins what is known as “contemporary sublime”, which “produce[s] a transcendent effect on the audience.” She explains, “We are all familiar with the masters of this aesthetic: Bergman, Wenders, Tarkovsky, Fellini. What distinguishes their works is that there is no peaceful, final message in their artworks; no comprehensible ‘happy ending’, or even obvious summation of the story that the spectator has experienced. These films create an ambiguous experience of ‘transcendence’, which—as with Kant’s sublime—cannot be grasped by our cognition.” She cites Ingmar Bergman’s *The Seventh Seal* (1957), which ends with “the questing knight and his mates walk[ing] along the beach, led on a rope by the dark figure of Death: surely this morbid coastal promenade is not a happy ending... Yet this celebrated finale creates a (painful) feeling of awe, wonder, transcendence. The contemporary sublime.” Bergman is famously known as an auteur, a master of his craft and aesthetic. His mastery is seen in his ability to manipulate the atmosphere of his film, creating a “contemporary sublime” experience.

Another masterpiece of awe is Christopher Nolan’s *Interstellar* (2014) analyzed in Mehmet Sari’s article, “The Emotional Appeal of Science Fiction Cinema: In Awe of *Interstellar*.”³ Sari argues that awe is at the emotional core of *Interstellar*, one of the most famous and successful science fiction films of all time. He also explores how the sublime is intertwined with science fiction in its special effects and imaginative capacities. In the case of *Interstellar*, he specifically showcases all the ways in which the film embodies the sublime, including its monolithic depictions of nature, use of juxtaposition, epic soundtrack, uncanny silence, and

² (Badt 2015)

³ (Sari 2021)

heavy focus on emotion as a core aspect. As stated by Sari, “when we see the tiny spaceship Endurance passing by planets, the movie overwhelms the viewer and makes them feel insignificant relative to the cosmos... The film points to the juxtaposition of the tiny and the immense. These scenes indicate the cosmic insignificance of humanity’s most advanced technology.” These striking visuals coupled with either “uncanny silence” or Zimmer’s award-winning soundtrack aim to create intense emotional experiences for the audience. Sari connects this to Dacher Keltner’s “primordial awe,” which is driven by power and obscurity. The celestial bodies of *Interstellar* possess both of these qualities, drawing our attention to our tiny, insignificant place in the universe.

Stanley Kubrick is another famous auteur for the distinct sensory experiences of his films. In her book, “Stanley Kubrick: Adapting the Sublime”⁴, Elisa Pezzotta analyzes Kubrick’s final six films, *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968), *A Clockwork Orange* (1971), *Barry Lyndon* (1975), *The Shining* (1980), *Full Metal Jacket* (1987), and *Eyes Wide Shut* (1999), all of which are adaptations. She argues that these films deviate from the source material in order to fulfill Kubrick’s cinematic style. He makes use of high-level relationships between the diegetic and extradiegetic worlds, essentially in-world and out-of-world events. For example, diegetic music is music that the characters can canonically hear in the story, while extradiegetic music is the score that only the audience can hear. Kubrick uses these distinctions to confuse and disorient the audience, the unfamiliarity of which contributes to a sublime experience. For example, in *2001: A Space Odyssey*, both the characters in the film and the audience hesitate in explaining the events of the film. Are the appearance of the monolith and the stargate purely natural phenomena? Or have they been brought about by supernatural circumstances? Pezzotta says, “the physical laws of the diegetic world do not seem to be different from those that govern our

⁴ (Pezzotta 2013)

own world,” and yet these uncanny and baffling events are taking place. “The uncanny elements of Kubrick’s science-fiction film... can be considered sublime because the spectators find themselves in the intellectual uncertainty of the fantastic-marvelous.” The characters of Kubrick’s bizarre worlds are trapped in a sublime landscape written around them. Their reactions often mimic those of the audience, translating the sublime situations on-screen into an awe-inspiring real-world experience for the viewer. As Pezzotta describes it, Bowman in *2001* is “a passive spectator of a sublime experience,” which sounds an awful lot like us, the audience.

That leads us to how the sublime experience of the film is made in just that, the viewing experience. The very act of us viewing the film is the most important step to actually making this happen. We’ve considered what the film creates for us, but have not yet analyzed how we might add or detract from what should be a sublime experience. The context in which the film is viewed has a huge impact on how we will enjoy or process it. This was empirically studied in a 2021 study by Kerstin Fröber and Roland Thomaschke, titled “In the Dark Cube: Movie Theater Context Enhances the Valuation and Aesthetic Experience of Watching Films.”⁵ Their findings suggest that watching a film for the first time in a cinema provides an emotionally and aesthetically superior experience to watching at home, which persists even after a second viewing.

After conducting a pilot experiment to determine an unknown film with a small variance in judgment, a group of participants were chosen who “comprised a majority of movie lovers, who watched films more often at home than in a movie theater. The most frequent arrangement for watching films at home was via online stream on a TV.” They split the participants into two groups, one who would see the film in the theater for the first time, and another who would see it at home for the first time. They subsequently split those groups into two more, one who would

⁵ (Fröber and Thomaschke 2021)

view the film in the same context, and one who would switch to the other context. After each viewing, the participants rated the film on a scale of 1 to 10, and filled out a standardized questionnaire about the emotions they felt during the viewing.

After reviewing the results they stated, “The present results provide clear-cut empirical evidence that a movie theater context is indeed boosting the cinematic experience in terms of an increase in a variety of aesthetic emotions. Moreover, the film was also rated about one point better on an overall judgment scale from 1 (worst film ever seen) to 10 (best film ever seen). This suggests that both output components in models of art experience (Pelowski et al., 2016)—emotions and judgments—were affected by the cinema context. These results are especially remarkable given that participants in their everyday life watched movies more often at home than in a movie theater.”

Based on the fact that the manner in which we view a film has a direct impact on our enjoyment of it, I believe we have a responsibility to consider our viewing context when watching a film. If we truly want to experience the sublime experience a director has carefully prepared for us, we are best off watching in a theater which boasts a large picture, high quality, loud speakers, and a dark, distraction-free environment. This of course may not always be the case. As stated earlier, a light-hearted comedy or documentary may best be viewed at home with some friends on a Saturday night. But for films that are more aesthetically inclined or based in spectacle, the quality of your viewing experience is key.

LESSON PLAN

Assigned readings: [Méliès article](#), [Interstellar article](#)

Have students prepare a movie clip they think inspires awe

Begin the lesson by asking the students about the clips they chose. “What do you think that movie does well?”, “How does it inspire awe and wonder?” After a few students answer, broaden the questions to “What makes a film ‘good’?” and “Why do we enjoy watching films?” Again, have a few students answer.

Now pose the question “Is cinema sublime?”

Transition into focus on Interstellar piece. Play this [scene](#) from Interstellar. Then ask “How does this scene embody the sublime?” and “How does this relate to ideas of power, obscurity, novelty as defined by Dacher Kelter and Edmund Burke?” Have a short discussion about this.

Then show this [scene](#) from Dune (2018) but first on mute. Also give basic context to the character of Paul Atreides and his situation. Then watch it again with the music and dialogue. Ask how the music and Paul’s dialogue fundamentally shifts the scene. How does the rhythm flow with the score, how does Villeneuve make use of montage to depict the sublime?

Also discuss how sci-fi may especially lean towards the sublime because of its novel concepts and future-sight approach to a story.

Now show a [clip](#) from *her* (2014), a film about a man in LA in a near future who falls in love with his AI assistant. Afterwards talk about the emotion of the scene. How do the emotions contribute to the sublime feeling of the film?

Pose the question, “What is the most important element of a film that contributes to its ability to be awe-inspiring? Or what specific fusion of elements? For example the climax of a love story with a light piano ballad, or a large battle scene with dramatic strings.” There is no right answer to this and it would be interesting to see what the students gravitate towards the most.

Now play this [clip](#) from The Grand Budapest Hotel by Wes Anderson. Ask students to think about all of the individual elements of these scenes. Look at the set design, the costumes, the dialogue, the acting, the music, the humor. Connecting to the Méliès piece, ask how is a film just one big magic trick? What really is the “magic of the movies”? How are we so utterly convinced of the setting and characters? Is this experience itself awe-inspiring and sublime? Not just the sublime depicted on the screen but the literal way in which the film is functioning to confound or amaze us? Connect this to Kant’s idea about agitation in the brain and realizing one’s own wonder. Like that “aha” moment while watching a film where you sit there and think, “Wow this is incredible.” Also consider what movies have inspired so much awe as to literally change society (Star Wars, Jurassic Park, 2001: A Space Odyssey, Marvel, DC, Pixar, etc.) What imaginative qualities do these films possess? Have a more drawn out discussion about all of these ideas as a whole.

Also ask students to challenge this idea if they disagree. Ask them to come up with counterexamples of films that are still amazing but don’t focus on inspiring awe or acting as a magic trick. What genres might not fit into this framework we’ve devised?

Finally, introduce the idea of the viewing context of a movie (locations, sound, distractions, etc.) and poll students on how they usually view movies, and what they think is most effective.

Then discuss findings of study by Fröber and Tomaschke. How it was set up, what they discovered, what it means for us. Ask the students their thoughts on it and encourage them to either connect it to how a theater experience might increase the amount of awe or agree/disagree with what someone else said.

Consider how we've pushed the boundaries of theater-going experiences. For example, the advent of 3D/4D technology, or IMAX theaters. Do these technologies add or subtract from the awe of the experience and if so how?

End on a note asking students to in the future consider the experience in which they're viewing a movie in order to get the most out of it (for whatever they're purpose is for watching e.g. awe, comedy, horror, etc).

Bibliography

- Badt, Karin. 2015. "The 'Sublime' Aesthetic in American Independent Cinema: Incomprehensibility, Violence, Awe and Paradox." *AngloSaxonica* 3 (9): 9–21. <https://ulices.letras.ulisboa.pt/wp-content/uploads/2016/07/ASaxoIII-N9-2.pdf#page=9>.
- Clemens, Patrick. 2023. "Georges Méliès: Conjuring Magic in Early Cinema – Fountaindale Public Library." Fountaindale Public Library District. August 31, 2023. <https://www.fountaindale.org/georges-melies-conjuring-magic-in-early-cinema/>.
- Fröber, Kerstin, and Roland Thomaschke. 2021. "In the Dark Cube: Movie Theater Context Enhances the Valuation and Aesthetic Experience of Watching Films." *Psychol Aesthet Creat Arts* 15 (3): 528–44. <https://doi.org/10.1037/aca0000295>.
- Pezzotta, Elisa. 2013. *Stanley Kubrick : Adapting the Sublime*. Jackson: University Press of Mississippi. Accessed May 3, 2024. ProQuest Ebook Central.
- Sarı, Mehmet. 2021. "The Emotional Appeal of Science Fiction Cinema: In Awe of Interstellar." *SineFilozofi* 6 (12): 1059–74. <https://doi.org/10.31122/Sinefilozofi.833598>.